Coming Next...



Brahmastra

Five years in the making, Alia calls her first film with Ranbir a "spectacle" unlike anything India has seen before. Written and directed by the couple's dear friend Ayan Mukerji, it also stars Amitabh Bachchan and Nagarjuna Akkineni

Darlings

"I think people will be quite intrigued and surprised when they see the trailer," says Alia of her maiden film from the banner, Eternal Sunshine. A dark comedy with Shefali Shah, Vijay Varma (of *Gully Boy* fame) and Roshan Mathew, it drops directly on OTT.

Rocky aur Rani Ki Prem Kahani

A decade after directing her in *Student of the Year*, Karan Johar teams up with his protégé in a romance with "a strong flavour of family values". Also starring Dharmendra, Jaya Bachchan, Shabana Azmi and Ranveer Singh

Heart of Stone

Alia's Hollywood debut is a Netflix-produced spy thriller with Gal Gadot (*Wonder Woman*) and James Dornan (*Fifty Shades of Grey*)

Jee Le Zaraa

Farhan Akhtar returns to the director's chair after a decade and puts together quite a cast. Priyanka Chopra and Katrina Kaif co-star in this road trip film



and Raus Koffman's award-winning documentary on Sonagachi. "I am not the kind of actor who sits down and takes notes," says Alia of her process.

It also helped that in an industry that worships the hero, Bhansali ceded the stage to his heroine, endowing Gangubai with flair, a devil-may-care demeanour and an attitude reminiscent of the leading men of the 1970s. Gangubai can swear like them, smoke like them, drink like them, fight like them and dream like them.

For Alia herself, it was essential that her Gangubai have a lot of swag. Beginning with the way she walked. "When I watch my own paparazzi videos," says Alia, "I feel like I walk strangely, like a duck. I had to make it more interesting." But while Alia wanted her walk to be distinct, she did not want it to appear forced. "When I watched *Pushpa*," she says, "I was just taken in by Allu Arjun's inherent swag. Swag has to be felt. It should be recognised as a talent."

Gangubai... is hardly the first project to demonstrate that Alia can carry a film on her shoulders. A newcomer to the industry, she played with elan a hostage who comes of age on a journey with her kidnapper in *Highway*. *Dear Zindagi* [2016] had her depicting the emotional vulnerabilities of a millennial woman seeking therapy. Working with her in the film, co-star Shah Rukh Khan would tell its producer Karan Johar, "The only fear about Alia Bhatt is that she is too good, too soon. She has to keep that going."

Alia chose to be in character for *Udta Punjab*, also released in 2016. She swapped her fancy smartphone for a "random, small phone" to travel to Punjab before her shoot schedule and kept to herself. Actor Ishaan, an assistant director on the film at that time, recalls how little Alia spoke on set. "She was aware that this character will need her to travel a long distance to get to and she was more than willing to make that journey and absorb anything I was going to give her," says writer-director Abhishek Chaubey, who roped in actor Pankaj Tripathi to do workshops with her. "She knew it [the film] was a big leap for her." Alia would go on to win multiple best female actor awards for her heartbreaking turn as an abducted woman coerced into drugs and abused.

With her string of successes, Alia joins the elite club of female actors who have tasted such